Faith under pressure

DANIEL 1, 3 & 6 / ABOUT 15 MINUTES

How can you stay true to God when the world around you pulls another way?

Read, notice, and choose one small step. You can think quietly or write. No phone is needed.

Online study + library

spelibertatis.github.io/come-follow-me-study/

Daniel 1 / At the king's table

Context (summary): Daniel and three other young captives are being trained to serve in Babylon's royal court. Their names, lessons, and daily food are chosen for them. Daniel decides he cannot accept the king's food and wine.

Daniel 1:8, 12 / KING JAMES VERSION

> 8 But Daniel purposed in his heart that he would not defile himself with the portion of the king's meat, nor with the wine which he drank: therefore he requested of the prince of the eunuchs that he might not defile himself.
>
> 12 Prove thy servants, I beseech thee, ten days; and let them give us pulse to eat, and water to drink.

"Purposed" means decided. "Defile" means make unclean. "Pulse" refers to plant foods such as seeds and grains.

Notice: Notice both Daniel's decision and his request. How does he stand firm while showing respect?

What happens next / summary: The steward agrees to a ten-day test. The account describes the four young men as healthier afterward and says God gives them knowledge and skill (1:14-17).

The text says Daniel wanted to avoid defilement; it does not explain every reason for refusing the provisions. This account is not a nutrition experiment for students to repeat.

Try: What could you say respectfully when someone invites you to do something against your beliefs?

Daniel 3 / Before the furnace

Context (summary): King Nebuchadnezzar orders people to worship a golden image or face a furnace. Shadrach, Meshach, and Abed-nego refuse. The king gives them another chance to bow.

Daniel 3:17-18 / KING JAMES VERSION

> 17 If it be so, our God whom we serve is able to deliver us from the burning fiery furnace, and he will deliver us out of thine hand, O king.
>
> 18 But if not, be it known unto thee, O king, that we will not serve thy gods, nor worship the golden image which thou hast set up.

"Deliver" means rescue. "Thine" means your.

Notice: What do the friends believe God can do? What will they choose even if He does not rescue them?

What happens next / summary: The friends are thrown into the furnace. The king sees them alive in the fire, and they come out unharmed (3:19-27).

This rescue is not a promise that every faithful person will escape suffering. Suffering does not mean someone lacks faith.

Try: How might "But if not" change the way you think about faith when life is difficult?

Daniel 6 / The open window

Context (summary): Under King Darius, officials try to trap Daniel. They persuade the king to forbid petitions to anyone except the king for thirty days. The penalty is the lions' den.

Daniel 6:10 / KING JAMES VERSION

> 10 Now when Daniel knew that the writing was signed, he went into his house; and his windows being open in his chamber toward Jerusalem, he kneeled upon his knees three times a day, and prayed, and gave thanks before his God, as he did aforetime.

"Aforetime" means before. Daniel is continuing a practice he already had.

Notice: Which words show that prayer was already part of Daniel's life? What does he do besides ask for help?

What happens next / summary: Daniel is placed in the den. In the morning he tells the king that God sent an angel, and he is brought out unharmed (6:16-23).

The chapter names Darius; scholars disagree about his historical identification. The narrative's lesson about devotion does not require pretending that question is settled.

Try: What simple habit could help you stay close to God before a difficult moment arrives?

Three stories. One next step.

Daniel makes a respectful request. His friends refuse to bow. Later, Daniel keeps praying. What connects their choices - and what is different?

Choose one small practice for your week: respond respectfully, stand by a belief, or make time to pray. What could that look like in your life?

A thought or question to take with me (optional):

You can stop here.

Keep one thought or question as you go into your week. Faith does not guarantee physical rescue; there is room for grief and unanswered questions.

For another day

Optional deeper study: read Daniel 1:3-20, 3:13-30, or 6:4-23. Look for the pressure, the response, and the outcome. The QR code on page 1 opens the online journey and its Explore Further library.

Your writing is yours. Sharing it with the class is optional. This handout is independent and is not affiliated with or endorsed by The Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints.